

THE FALSE HYDRA

A 5TH EDITION REFERENCE GUIDE FOR RUNNING A FALSE HYDRA ADVENTURE



THE MYTH

The false hydra has pasty white skin and a bulbous body with elongated necks that twist up to their heads. The heads are human-esque, but it has shadowy crevices where the eyes would be and its extended jaw and wide mouth reveal tall, pearly white teeth. When its first face breaks through the soil, it begins to sing.

While it sings, it creates gaps in our attention and is completely ignored: neither seen nor heard nor consciously noticed in any other way. **While it sings, it exists in our blind spot. It uses its song to feed and continue growing unnoticed. It absorbs the basic memories of whatever it eats.** The song works similarly to magic like charm, but is also akin to suggestion, dream, and modify memory. The false hydra becomes almost impossible to destroy once it has multiple heads as it can then sing while it feeds.

False hydras supposedly originate spontaneously as masses of flesh in the ground that germinate on lies, fear, and confusion, until large enough to feed on people. It burrows until its lair is underneath a city it can feed on. Its burrowing can create areas prone to collapse, but it prefers to remain partially above ground to continue its song. Once the city can no longer sustain it, it burrows to the next closest settlement.

It is suggested that the false hydra may be visible in mirrors due to the added degree of separation. Because of its song and the fact that most people who do see it are quickly eaten, the false hydra remains largely a myth.

RESISTING THE HYDRA

Silence. Plugging their ears could work to block out the song. Spells (such as *Blindness/Deafness*, *Silence*, and *Warding Wind*) and other magical effects that cause deafness would also work.

Mirrors. If they use mirrors or other reflective surfaces, they will see things as they truly are. Note: if fighting the hydra with mirrors, they attack at disadvantage.

Memory. Some spells (such as *Arcane Eye*, *Detect Evil/Good*, *Dispel Evil/Good*, *Foresight*, *Protection from Evil/Good*, *True Seeing*) could help break the song's charm.

THE TOWN AS IT REALLY IS

If anyone in the party is able to block out the song or looks through a mirror, they will see the town as it really is. The streets are smashed up with large holes from underground. Blood and pieces of bodies litter the roads and sidewalks. The vast majority of damage, however, is at the town hall and the immediately surrounding area: the false hydra has clearly made space under the town hall as its main lair.

They will also be able to see several of the false hydra heads. **It has a number of heads equal to half the number of PCs plus 1.** All but one are singing, as one is attacking a local towns member.

FALSE HYDRA

Large–Huge aberration, neutral evil

Armor Class 15 (natural)

Hit Points 150 + 100 / additional head

Speed 5ft.; Burrow 40ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	8 (-2)	20 (+5)	20 (+5)

Condition Immunities blinded, charmed, deafened, grappled, prone, stunned, knocked unconscious

Saving Throws Wisdom, Charisma

Senses Passive Perception 15; Darkvision 120 ft.

Languages Understands the languages of its victims

Blind Song. All hostile creatures that can hear the Hydra sing must make a DC15 Wisdom saving throw at the start of their turn. If the Hydra sings with more than one head, all hostile creatures must subtract 1d4 from their saving throw. **On a failure,** the creature forgets the Hydra is there.

Actions

Multiattack. The Hydra can use a claw attack and a bite attack on its turn.

Claw. *Melee Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 10ft., one target. *Hit* 8 (1d8 + 3) slashing damage.

Grapple. If the Hydra succeeds on a claw attack, it can choose to grapple the target instead of dealing damage. (The hydra can only grapple one creature at a time and can not use its claw attack while grappling a creature.)

Bite. *Melee Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 15ft., one target. *Hit* 9 (1d10 + 3) piercing damage.

Bonus Actions

Sing. The Hydra can use a bonus action to stop singing or to start its song with an additional head.

Regrowth. The Hydra can use a bonus action to begin regrowing a head that has died. It takes three Regrowth bonus actions to fully regrow a head. It regains 20 hit points each time it uses Regrowth.

Reactions

Multireact. The Hydra can make two reactions per round as long as it has three or more heads.

Wail. After taking damage, the Hydra can use a reaction to wail. Creatures within 5ft of the Hydra when it wails takes 2d4 psychic damage.

RAYHASFELD

The small town of Rayhaseld has been taken over by a false false hydra. It has built its lair within/below the town hall.

RESIDENTIAL

The town's population looks like it should be a few hundred, based on the number of residential houses they can see, but the number of people they see out and about suggests a population much smaller.

Additionally, many of the houses appear abandoned or dilapidated. Some look more overgrown than others. People won't remember any neighbours having lived in those houses, yet they were clearly once lived in (name signs, furniture, etc).

If they investigate any of the homes, some will be extremely dusty with completely rotten/moldy food, others will only be starting to look dirty with some food starting to go bad. They could also find hand mirrors and a book on cultural, historical, and religious myths that mentions the false hydra.

DREAMS & DRAMS

The Dreams & Drams tavern/inn is a couple minutes south of the main street, on the side of the main road. It is a cozy, inviting looking building and is run by a kind, middle aged couple named **Fib and Lev**.

A book on mythical creatures that mentions the false hydra could be found on the take-one-leave-one bookshelf in the inn. *(Note: depending how early they find the book in their investigation, you could mention other creatures the book references to make it less obvious. Even better if they are creatures that will come up later in your game or that have already come up!)*

MAIN STREET

The town has one main business street.

RAYHASFELD TOWN HALL & LIBRARY

- **Varra Cherokina**, female human secretary
- If they use *detect evil* or a class feature like *primeval awareness*, they will sense an aberration. If they use *detect magic*, they could see a faint aura around seemingly nothing.
- Despite portraits and documents, anyone asked will claim there has never been a mayor.
- If they search for a census or similar document, they will discover the town should be bustling with people.
- If they make use of the library, they could find books that reference or that include sections specifically about aberrations and the myth of the false hydra.

CHURCH

- **Alston Folkor**, male gnome caretaker

SMELT IT, DEALT IT

- **Smithy**
- **Atala Basha**, female human blacksmith
- If Atala becomes aware of the Hydra, she will help fight

BORN & BREAD

- Grocery
- **Borivik Staygona**, male human shopkeeper/baker
- If Borivik becomes aware of the Hydra, he will help fight

X MARKS THE SPOT

- Antique shop
- **Zook Knipper**, elderly male gnome shopkeeper
- The antique shop is stuffed with furniture and knick knacks - it has far more things to sell than the party would expect for a town of this size.
- There are also first edition books of poetry and books with beautiful, special edition covers, including a set of encyclopaedia. If the party were to look through the books, they could find poems about the false hydra or a section on aberrations in the encyclopaedias.
- They party could purchase beautiful silver hand mirrors (50gp each).

RAYHASFELD CLINIC

- **Tammith Dyethara**, female human doctor
- If the party investigates the clinic, they could find (DC10) two labeled Potions of Healing and (DC15) an unlabeled bottle of Eye Drops of True Seeing.

SHEAR DELIGHT

- Barber shop / salon
- **Vikrim Tunesea**, male human barber
- If the party go to the barber, they could find hand mirrors. A DC18 Perception check will allow them to catch a glimpse of the false hydra in a large mirror that can make out part of the town hall.

WELL STOCKED ONE STOP SHOP

- General store
- **Oda Timbers**, elderly female gnome shopkeeper

SEW WHAT?

- Clothing shop
- **Ellyjobell Folkrun**, young female gnome tailor / sewer

ABANDONED BUSINESSES

Some buildings on main street appear empty, unused, and/or abandoned. If anyone is asked about them, they won't remember those shops ever having been owned or open for business. If the party were to investigate, they will find clear evidence of these shops having been open at some point (receipts, accounting books, half eaten snacks, etc etc).

THE SECRET INGREDIENT

- Alchemy shop
- If the party investigates, they could find: (DC12) two unlabeled Potions of Blindness/Deafness; (DC15) one unlabeled Potion of Clarity; (DC18) a book (with a "Property of Rayhasfeld Town Hall & Library" sticker on the spine) that is dog-eared to a page on aberrations, which includes a footnote on the myth of the false hydra.

WHAT AN ASS!

- Barn selling donkeys, horses, and ox
- There are still animals grazing in the gated yard

WAKE & BAKE

- Cafe

WATER TO WINE

- Winery

STICKS & STONES

- Stonemason and carpentry

GENERAL CLUES / ATMOSPHERE

- Cats will puff up or hiss and run away.
- Dogs may start barking or growling (will defend themselves if the party attack pre-emptively).
- People may seemingly trip over nothing.
- The party's own hands may reach for the weapon without them consciously deciding to do so.
- People will generally appear uneasy and like they are trying to remember something.
- People may be carrying hand mirrors with them and will not be sure why if asked.
- Townspeople may be found crying, but won't even realize and will be extremely confused as to why if pointed out.

EVENT CLUES

- When they check in at Dreams & Drums, Lev will tell them that her husband Fib makes a great breakfast that is included in the price. The next morning, Fib is no where to be seen and all they get for breakfast is toast and coffee. If they ask Lev about Fib, she will claim she has never been married. If they don't drop the conversation, tears will start to stream down her face and she will coldly say she needs to get back to work.
- The first evening in town, they can see a figure lighting the street lamps on the main street, but the next night only half of the lamps are lit. Anybody asked about it will be unsure how the lamps were lit or if anyone ever did it regularly, and will be confused about if the street is normally lit up or dark at night.
- The church bell rings out at regular intervals for the first day and a half, but then is no longer heard. Anybody asked about it will say that there's never been a bell ringer.
- Tammith, the doctor, could mention offhandedly how busy she is. If pressed, she'll say it seems to be mostly minor accidents like people falling or bumping into things, but there have been a few animal incidents as well. (Note: these are both related to the false hydra. People may trip over the aberration but are lucky to survive as it is eating someone else at the moment, and animals may be able to see the false hydra and accidentally hurt their owners or others nearby due to fear and panicked defense.)
- The party could overhear Tammith saying that she needs to deliver eye drops to Varra at the town hall. Later that day or the next day (if the party ever goes to the town hall), she is nowhere to be seen and nobody remembers her. If they search the font desk, they could find Eye Drops of True Seeing.
- If walking through the residential area, they could see a local arriving home and leave the gate open behind them. The party will notice a sign on the gate that reads "Please keep closed - Beware of dog" as well as a small doghouse on the lawn. If they talk to the person, they will look confused and say they've never had a dog.

ADDITIONAL LOCALS

- Yuldra Stayanoga, female human
- Caramip Scheppen, female gnome
- Zasheir Rein, male human
- Dimble Durrem, male gnome
- Jasmal Jassan, female human
- Loopmottin Wrangle, female gnome
- Vladislak Mournzara, male human

HOOKS

1. SIMPLE HAPPENSTANCE

Your party happens to pass through a town with a false hydra. The town seems generally odd (empty shops, not a lot of people for the number of houses, etc) and if they stay the night at the Dreams & Drums tavern, the next morning, Fib is nowhere to be seen and completely forgotten by his wife, Lev.

This can work if your party are naturally suspicious or act on the slightest hint of something strange occurring. If it takes more effort for them to buy in, this may not work.

2. THE FORGOTTEN PARTY MEMBER

Your party is staying the night in town - whether passing through or purposely having journeyed there. In the morning, they find evidence that another person was traveling with them - personal belongings tossed down next to their own, another cot seemingly having been slept in - but they remember nothing about them and the tavern owners won't remember anyone else with them. A journal or other evidence to solidify that they were actually companions can help.

This can easily be done, but be aware that you are essentially retconning the party's entire adventure thus far.

3. A LETTER

Your party or a single party member receives a letter inviting them to the town for one reason or another. Once there, they will start to notice odd occurrences. Once they've learned about the false hydra, or with a high enough Wisdom save, they could see additional information in the letter that they don't remember having been there before: lines like "please help" and "come quickly" are shakily written within the regular text of the letter, which are "unread" due to the hydra's song.

For example, at first read the letter might say "I would like to invite you to dinner. It's been so long since I've seen you." but the letter actually reads "I would like to invite you to dinner. It's eating us. It's been so long since I've seen you."

This can work if you can logically tie in who would be sending the letter and why.

4. A DIFFERENT ADVENTURE

Your party has come to town based on information of a different problem the town is facing, such as goblin attacks. But none of the locals know anything about it. Upon investigating, they find evidence that the original problem was real, such as a now goblinless goblin lair.

This can work if the party would want to know why the locals don't remember the original issue, otherwise they may just accept it was dealt with and move on.